

CSCI 1200 Syllabus

Introduction to Computational Thinking

Fall 2026, 3 credits

Section 100	Section 800
MF 3:35 pm - 4:25 pm	MF 9:05-9:55
Engineering Center ECCS 201	Engineering Center ECCR 211
Prof. Alex Chavakov	Prof. Kathy Nielsen
Office: ECOT 741	Office: ECOT 635
Office Hours: TBD or by appointment.	Office Hours: TBD
agc@colorado.edu	Katherine.Nielsen@Colorado.edu

Contact us on Piazza

The best way to get help is by posting on Piazza, an online tool for course communication. See canvas for accessing it. You may make private posts if the information is of a private nature. Do not post assignment solutions in a public post.

Lab sections

Course & Section Numbers	Days	Start	End	Location
CSCI 1200-011	W	11:15 AM	12:55 PM	ECES 114
CSCI 1200-012	W	1:10 PM	2:50 PM	ECES 114
CSCI 1200-013	W	3:05 PM	4:45 PM	ECES 114
CSCI 1200-014	W	5:00 PM	6:40 PM	ECES 114
CSCI 1200-801	W	9:05 AM	10:45 AM	ECCR 211

Teaching Assistants

You may go to the office hours of any TA for help. See the office hour calendar on canvas.

Email	Name
alna9410@colorado.edu	Alireza Nadali
kuki9329@colorado.edu	Kunha Kim
jana7431@colorado.edu	Jannatun Naim

Course Information

Teaches computational thinking and techniques for writing computer programs using the Python programming language. Intended for students who realize that computational skills are beneficial to all fields of study, but who have little or no experience in programming or are not Computer Science majors. Students will be expected to create computer programs to solve problems in a range of disciplines. Does not count as Computer Science credit for the Computer Science BA, BS, or minor. Degree credit not granted for this course and [LING 1200](#) or [INFO 1701](#).

Many of you come to this class with different levels of exposure to computers and programming. For those of you for whom this is your first time programming: welcome! Rest assured; this class is for you. Many of the members of our instructional staff were once in the same boat that you're in now!

Learning Outcomes

1. Take a systematic approach to problem solving and to formulate algorithms/strategies with a computational approach.
 - a. To understand the form and function of computer programming languages.
 - b. To know the steps in a software development process.
 - c. To understand programs following the input, process, output (IPO) pattern.
 - d. Use Python to implement, test, and debug solutions to computational problems
2. Understand how computing and computational processes interact with the world at large.
 - a. Apply computational knowledge to the analysis of current events and innovations.
 - b. Understand and be able to articulate problems that computer scientists study at a high level

Textbooks, Materials, and Technologies

It is important to get yourself set up and familiar with the following. Instructions are here: [Getting Started](#)

- ZyBooks
- iClicker
- Canvas
- CSeI

Course Activities and Grades

	Percentage of Final Grade	Drop Lowest
Quizzes	30	1
Lecture Participation	10	3
Lab Participation	5	2
Lab Assignments	5	2
Homework	5	3
Project	15	
Grading Interview	10	
Final	20	

Canvas will automatically drop your lowest assignments and quizzes, so there are no make ups for missed class sessions or assignments. Dropping these grades accounts for being sick, out of town, or any other reason for your absences.

Check canvas for due dates and late allowances. No exceptions to these dates will be given to individuals. You do not need to email instructors or provide any reason for absences. If you have an extended illness or excused absence of a month or more, contact your professor.

Grading Details

1. Quizzes. In lieu of midterm exams, there will be quizzes approximately every other Friday starting during Week 3. Your lowest quiz grade will be dropped. The quizzes will be 25 minutes long and will take place during class on Friday. These quizzes are cumulative, but each has a main focus.

Quiz #	Date	Main Focus
Quiz 1	Friday, Sep. 11	Variables, Expressions, and Types
Quiz 2	Friday, Sep. 25	Branching
Quiz 3	Friday, Oct. 9	Loops
Quiz 4	Friday, Oct. 23	Functions
Quiz 5	Friday, Nov. 6	Lists and Dictionaries
Quiz 6	Friday, Nov. 20	TBD

2. **Lecture Participation.** Attending class is critical to understanding the material and establishing a community of learners. To encourage attendance every lecture will include iClicker questions, lecture activities, and/or programming exercises. These activities are mostly graded on participation. You can drop your three lowest scores.
3. **Lab Participation.** Labs occur every Wednesday during the semester for approximately 2 hours. Labs provided space to practice your programming skills and deepen your understanding of computational thinking. You are required to attend and actively engage with the lab sections. Your two lowest lab participation scores are dropped.
4. **Lab Assignments.** Each lab has a corresponding set of programming exercises on ZyBooks. The deadline to submit the lab exercises is the Friday after the lab at 11:59PM, but we do give a free no questions asked extension until Sundays at 11:59PM. Your two lowest scores are dropped.
5. **Homework.** Homework is composed of three different parts (pre-lecture reading and participation exercises, pre-lab reading and participation exercises, and challenge activities) all in ZyBooks. The pre-work must be completed by the deadline, so you are prepared to engage with the material during lecture and lab. The challenge activities are due Friday at 11:59PM, but we do give a free no questions asked extension until Sundays at 11:59PM. Your three lowest scores are dropped.
6. **Project.** Each student will complete an individual project. More details will be announced during Weeks 10 and 11. Part of your final project grade will be an individual grading interview (similar to the one described below) during Weeks 13 and 14.
7. **Grading Interview.** Grading interviews are 12-15 minute, individually scheduled conversations with a TA to answer questions based on the content of the course. The grading interview covers through Week 7 of the course. More information about grading interviews and questions will be released during Week 6.
8. **Final Exam.** The final exam is required, in-person, cumulative and is worth 20% of your grade. See the university website for scheduling details.

Grade Scale

The scores listed in the table below will guarantee the corresponding grades. There is no rounding up. Your final score must be above the following cut offs. For example, if your score is 82.7 you will receive a B-. We reserve the right to lower these cutoffs, but never raise them.

Letter Grade	A	A-	B+	B	B-	C+	C	C-	D+	D	D-	F
Percent	93	90	87	83	80	77	73	70	67	63	60	<60

Course Calendar

See the modules page and assignments in canvas for the course due dates. Modules are released on a two week rolling basis (i.e., you will always have access to the current module and the module for the next week). The following is provided as a tentative overview of the course schedule. Note that there is a lab scheduled for every week on Wednesday.

Week #	Content	Summative Assessments
Week 0 (Aug. 21)	Syllabus	
Week 1 (Aug. 24)	Introduction to Python	
Week 2 (Aug. 31)	Variables and Expressions	
Week 3 (Sep. 7)	Types	Quiz 1
Week 4 (Sep. 14)	Branching	
Week 5 (Sep. 21)	Loops	Quiz 2
Week 6 (Sep. 28)	Functions 1	
Week 7 (Oct. 5)	Strings	Quiz 3
Week 8 (Oct. 12)	Lists and Dictionaries	Grading Interviews
Week 9 (Oct. 19)	Functions 2	Quiz 4, Grading Interviews
Week 10 (Oct. 26)	Project and Additional Topics ¹	
Week 11 (Nov. 2)	Project and Additional Topics	Quiz 5
Week 12 (Nov. 9)	Project and Additional Topics	
Week 13 (Nov. 16)	Project and Additional Topics	Quiz 6, Project Grading Interviews
Fall Break (November 23-November 27)		
Week 14 (Nov. 30)	Project and Additional Topics	Project Grading Interviews
In-Person Final Exam: Date and Time TBD		

¹ For weeks 10 through 14 students will be working on their project and course materials such as Files, Exceptions, Modules as selected by each instructor

AI and collaboration Policies

All students of the University of Colorado at Boulder are responsible for knowing and adhering to the **University's Honor Code**. Violations of this policy may also include cheating, plagiarism, academic dishonesty, fabrication, lying, bribery, and threatening behavior.

Collaboration on homework assignments is allowed and encouraged. Students are most successful when they are working with other students to understand new concepts. For your learning it is essential that you fully understand the code you develop and turn in.

ALL exams will be required to be **completed without outside resources**. The use of outside resources would violate the Honor code and be taken seriously.

When working with a large language model or another person, you may ask questions to help you learn, you may not have them do your work for you. You are responsible for understanding the code that you turn in.

How to adhering to the Collaboration Policy:

Some **examples of violating the collaboration policy** include, but are not limited to:

- Copying solutions from AI or websites like chegg.com, coursehero.com, and other “tutoring” websites
- Sharing a file (source code) with someone
- Submitting a file that someone else shared with you, including tutors
- Stealing a copy of someone else’s work and submitting it as your own, even with modification
- Posting on websites like chegg.com. coursehero.com or craigslist.org to solicit an entire solution to an to assignment
- Change or manipulate data or test cases (i.e. values, test data) in order to manipulate assignment or project solutions.
- You are not allowed to copy entire solutions from or AI-based tools such as Github Copilot, Claude, Gemini, ChatGPT, etc
 - Do not paste the question prompt into an AI and turn in the response
 - Do not ask an AI to write you a whole function
 - Do not paste your entire solution into an AI to ask it for help
 - It is important to learn how to break down a problem into smaller problems.
 - You should be able to explain any code you have written to your TA and may be asked to do so at any point during the semester. Inability to do so will result in a 0 on the respective assignment/task and you may face academic violation.

Examples of collaborating correctly:

- Asking for help at the level of one line of code (not a whole solution, nor function, nor block of code)
- Sharing parts of pseudo-code.
- Asking another student or AI for a helpful suggestion with a small and specific aspect of the problem, such as how to solve an error code.
- Reviewing another student's code for bugs/errors.
- Asking a student, teacher or AI to explain a concept, a command, or one line of code.
- Asking a student, tutor, or teacher to brainstorm about how to break down a problem into smaller steps. Students and teachers can provide general suggestions, not solve the problem for you.
- Working together on the whiteboard, or paper, to figure out how to approach and solve the problem.

One way to know you are collaborating well is if everyone fully understands the solution that is developed. If you do not understand what is in the work you are submitting, you need to spend the time to learn the material before you submit your assignment. This collaboration policy requires that you be able to create the code (or solve the problem) on your own before you submit your assignment. If any member of the instructional team believes that you are submitting someone else's work, you might be called upon to explain your solution in a one-on-one meeting with the instructor to receive credit for the work.

Any discovered incidents of violation of this collaboration policy will be treated as violations of the University's Academic Integrity Policy and may lead to an automatic academic sanction in the course and a report to both the College of Engineering and Applied Science and the Honor Code Council. The academic sanction may include an automatic F or being dropped from the course.

Collaboration boundaries are hard to define crisply and may differ from class to class. If you are in any doubt about where they lie for a particular course, it is your responsibility to ask the course instructor.

Other information on the Honor Code can be found at <https://www.colorado.edu/sccr/honor-code>

CU Boulder Required Syllabus Statements:

Honor Code

All students enrolled in a University of Colorado Boulder course are responsible for knowing and adhering to the [Honor Code](#). Violations of the Honor Code may include but are not limited to: plagiarism (including use of paper writing services or technology [such as essay bots]), cheating, fabrication, lying, bribery, threat, unauthorized access to academic materials, clicker fraud, submitting the same or similar work in more than one course without permission from all course instructors involved, and aiding academic dishonesty. Understanding the course's syllabus is a vital part of adhering to the Honor Code.

All incidents of academic misconduct will be reported to Student Conduct & Conflict Resolution: StudentConduct@colorado.edu. Students found responsible for violating the Honor Code will be assigned resolution outcomes from Student Conduct & Conflict Resolution and will be subject to academic sanctions from the faculty member. Visit [Honor Code](#) for more information on the academic integrity policy.

Accommodation for Disabilities, Temporary Medical Conditions, and Medical Isolation

If you qualify for accommodations because of a disability, please submit your accommodation letter from Disability Services to your faculty member in a timely manner so that your needs can be addressed. Disability Services determines accommodations based on documented disabilities in the academic environment. Information on requesting accommodations is located on the [Disability Services website](#). Contact Disability Services at 303-492-8671 or DSinfo@colorado.edu for further assistance. If you have a temporary medical condition, see [Temporary Medical Conditions](#) on the Disability Services website.

If you have a temporary illness, injury or required medical isolation for which you require adjustment, please contact your professor.

Accommodation for Religious Obligations

Instructional faculty members must make every reasonable effort to accommodate all students who have conflicts with scheduled exams, assignment deadlines or required attendance due to a religious observance. Whenever possible, students must notify the instructional faculty member at least two weeks in advance of the expected exam, assignment deadline, or attendance conflict to request an accommodation for religious observance. If the start date of the course is less than two weeks before the date of requested accommodation, students must

notify the instructional faculty member on the start date of the course. See the [Student Academic Accommodations for Religious Observances Policy](#) for more information.

In this class, please contact your instructor at the beginning of the semester if you will need to miss a class meeting due religious obligations.

Student Names and Pronouns

CU Boulder recognizes that students' legal information does not always align with how they identify. If you wish to have a name other than your legal name appear on your instructors' class rosters and in Canvas, or if you wish to choose pronouns to appear on your instructors' class rosters and in Canvas, visit the [Registrar's website](#) for instructions on how to change your personal information in university systems.

Classroom Behavior

Students and faculty are responsible for maintaining an appropriate learning environment in all instructional settings, whether in person, remote, or online. Failure to adhere to such behavioral standards may be subject to discipline. Professional courtesy and sensitivity are especially important with respect to individuals and topics dealing with race, color, national origin, sex, pregnancy, age, disability, creed, religion, sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression, veteran status, marital status, political affiliation, or political philosophy.

Additional classroom behavior information

- [Student Classroom and Course-Related Behavior Policy](#).
- [Student Code of Conduct](#).
- [Office of Institutional Equity and Compliance](#).

Sexual Misconduct, Discrimination, Harassment and/or Related Retaliation

CU Boulder is committed to fostering a productive and welcoming learning, working, and living environment. University policy prohibits [protected-class](#) discrimination and harassment, sexual misconduct (harassment, exploitation, and assault), intimate partner abuse (dating or domestic violence), stalking, and related retaliation by or against members of our community on- or

off-campus. Denial of an approved accommodation for disability, religious observance, or pregnancy or pregnancy related medical conditions may be discriminatory.

The [Office of Institutional Equity and Compliance \(OIEC\)](#) addresses these concerns, and individuals who have been subjected to misconduct can contact OIEC at 303-492-2127 or email OIEC@colorado.edu. Information about university policies, [OIEC reporting options](#), and [OIEC support resources](#) including confidential services can be found on the [OIEC website](#).

Faculty and graduate instructors are required to inform OIEC when someone discloses misconduct regardless of when or where it occurred. This is to ensure that those impacted receive outreach from OIEC about resolution options and support resources. To learn more about reporting and support options for a variety of concerns, visit the [Don't Ignore It page](#).

Mental Health and Wellness

The University of Colorado Boulder is committed to supporting students' mental health and overall wellbeing. If personal, academic, or emotional challenges are affecting your wellbeing or success, [Counseling and Psychiatric Services \(CAPS\)](#), is here to help. CAPS offers counseling, referrals, psychiatric care, crisis support, and much more. Visit CAPS in the C4C, or call (303) 492-2277, 24/7.